

Impact: Medium Difficulty: Easy-Medium Misuse risk: Low

## CORE FORMULA

Name the decision -> Options on the table -> Stakes and trade-offs -> Who decides

## MINIMUM VIABLE MOVE

Before any group decision, spend thirty seconds naming: what decision are we making, what are the options, and who makes the final call?

## BEST FOR

- Group decisions that stall without a clear frame
- High-stakes decisions where options need to be visible
- Meetings that run long without landing on a decision
- Situations where 'who decides' is ambiguous

## PHRASE BANK

### Decision Framing · Setting up the decision clearly

- "The decision we are making is: ..."
- "Let me name what we are actually deciding."
- "The options as I see them are X and Y."
- "The question we need to answer before we leave is: ..."
- "This is a decision about X — not about Y."
- "The decision owner is [Name]. We are here to inform it, not to make it."
- "To be clear on the stakes: if we choose X, we get A but lose B."
- "What is the decision, and who makes it?"

### Option Naming · Making options explicit

- "Option one is X. Option two is Y. Are there others I am missing?"
- "I want to name the options explicitly before we discuss them."
- "The options as currently framed are: ..."
- "Is the decision binary — X or Y — or are there more options?"
- "What is the option we are not yet naming?"

## WEAK -> BETTER -> BEST

1. Weak: Group discusses for an hour with no clear decision framework

Better: Let us agree on what we are deciding.

**Best: The decision is X. Options are A and B. Trade-offs are [stated]. [Name] makes the final call.**

2. Weak: Naming the decision after the discussion is over

Better: So it sounds like we have decided...

**Best: Name the decision before discussion begins.**

3. Weak: Implicit options that different people understand differently

Better: I think we are deciding between two approaches.

**Best: Explicit options named and agreed before analysis begins.**

## DECISION TREE

**If The group is discussing without clarity on what is being decided**

Stop. Name the decision.

*"Let me name what I think we are deciding — is that right?"*

**If Options are implicit but not stated**

Make them explicit.

*"The options as I see them are X and Y. Are there others?"*

**If Trade-offs are being avoided**

Name them directly.

*"If we go with X, we get A but lose B. I want to make sure we are choosing that consciously."*

**If Who decides is unclear**

Name it before the discussion, not after.

*"Before we get into this — whose decision is it? I want to make sure we are clear."*

## SCENARIOS

**Team meeting that keeps going in circles**

Stop and name what decision you are all trying to make. — "I want to step back — what is the actual decision we are trying to reach?"

**High-stakes decision with multiple stakeholders**

Name the options and trade-offs before anyone advocates for a position. — "Before anyone argues for a position — let me name what the options are."

**Decision where people disagree about who decides**

Surface the who-decides question first. — "I want to be clear on who makes this call before we discuss it."

**Decision being deferred repeatedly**

Name what is causing the deferral — often it is an unnamed trade-off. — "The reason we keep deferring this is we have not named the real trade-off: X vs Y."

## WHEN NOT TO USE

- When the decision is urgent and time spent establishing criteria delays it critically.
- When criteria are already agreed and restating them is unnecessary overhead.
- When the decision is a simple preference call with no meaningful trade-offs to evaluate.

## 7-DAY PRACTICE DRILL

**Day 1 — Decision audit**

After your next meeting, note: was the decision clearly named? Were the options explicit? Was the owner clear?

**Day 2 — Name the decision**

In one meeting, name the decision before discussion begins.

**Day 3 — Options explicit**

Practice naming the options explicitly — not as advocacy but as a shared starting point.

**Day 4 — Name the trade-off**

In one decision, explicitly name what is being gained and what is being given up.

**Day 5 — Name the owner**

Before any group decision, name who makes the final call.

**Day 6 — Full frame**

Use the full frame (decision + options + trade-offs + owner) in one real meeting.

**Day 7 — Calibration**

Did decisions land more cleanly? Did meetings end with clearer outcomes? Did any framing feel forced?

## AFTER-ACTION CHECKLIST

- Did I name the decision explicitly before the discussion?
- Were the options made explicit and agreed?

- Were the trade-offs named clearly?
- Was the decision owner identified before the discussion?
- Did the group leave with a clear, stated decision?
- Did I avoid using the frame to pre-determine the outcome?
- Was the decision confirmed by the owner at the end?